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SHEKEL שק"ל

Inclusion for People
with Disabilities
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Request for Funding:
Emergency Wartime Needs for People with Disabilities

In times of war and national crisis, people with disabilities are among the most vulnerable sectors of the community and are in critical need of intensive support and assistance, to ensure their safety and wellbeing.

SHEKEL is now mobilizing in full emergency mode to ensure the safety and welfare of hundreds of people with disabilities throughout Israel who are now living in physical danger and immense emotional distress, surrounded by unrelenting sirens and rocket explosions that have become part of their daily reality.

Immediate Emergency Support

1. Nation-wide Emergency Therapeutic Call Center

Upon the outbreak of war, SHEKEL's therapeutic centers launched a nation-wide emergency hotline as an urgent measure to provide immediate therapeutic assistance and guidance for children and adults with disabilities, as well their families and carers, throughout the country. The need for this is now acute, since children and adults with disabilities are exceptionally vulnerable to paralyzing trauma and anxiety. Moreover, the Iran war is now retriggering old traumas for many previous victims of war with disabilities, who experienced and witnessed atrocities and terror following October 7., or were traumatized by evacuation where they were wrenched from familiar routines and communities. Their trauma, in turn, impacts the entire family, many of whom are themselves dealing with the trauma of war while caring for a loved one with disabilities. They often feel helpless to assist their family members with disabilities. For children and adults with disabilities, trauma is often exacerbated by a sense of helplessness and frustration derived from a limited understanding of what is going around them, combined with apprehensive surroundings.

The call center hotline provides immediate short-term non-frontal therapeutic intervention through zoom/phone calls, with an option for further long-term therapy, according to need for people with disabilities, as well as guidance and counseling for their families and the teams that work with them. The call center is manned by a multi-professional team of psychologists, clinical social workers, and therapists, all of whom specialize in trauma therapy for people with disabilities. The call center will remain open for at least two months in order to begin dealing with emergency onset of PTSD symptoms.
Since SHEKEL is the only Israel non-profit organization with expertise and experience in trauma therapy for people with disabilities, our work has now become critical for people with disabilities throughout the country.

2. Housing: Staff and security

With the onset of the war, all vocational, day center and cultural/social activities, were immediately closed down, under instruction from the Home Front. This means residents are now confined to their housing apartments 24/7, necessitating staff presence all hours of the day and night. This greatly increases the number of staff shifts needed as ordinarily residents

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are not home during normal daytime hours. For many of SHEKEL's housing residents, SHEKEL constitutes their real-world family. Many literally have nowhere else to go. As approximately 150 SHEKEL apartments are located in Israel's central, and Jerusalem regions, our housing residents are now exposed to massive ongoing missile fire barrages and frequent explosions, causing extreme distress and immediate danger. In apartments where residents have severe multiple disabilities and use wheel chairs, one staff member is needed per resident in order to ensure all residents safely enter the safe rooms on time. In addition, under the new security conditions, extra staff members are needed in apartments during the night.

A high proportion of male staff are now missing due to army enlistment, while many female staff with young children are unable to come to work, so that SHEKEL now has to take on additional new staff in addition to adding daytime shifts.

Emergency war time expenses

Costs of call center for 1 month	$35,000
Cost of extra staff for 1 apartment for 1 month:	$25,000
Total	**$60,000**
Request for funding:	**$30,000**